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The Influence of a Film on Destination Image and the Desire to Travel: a Cross-Cultural Comparison

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ABSTRACT

The objective of this study was to measure the immediate impacts of a film on the perceptions of viewers from different countries. The film chosen for this experiment was the *Motorcycle Diaries* in which South America was featured prominently in the film. Using established scales from the tourism and marketing literature, viewers from the USA, Canada and Spain were surveyed before and after seeing the film, and results showed that the film did change the viewers' perceptions of South America. After watching the film, a large percentage of the respondents expressed a desire to visit the countries seen in the film, with Canadians showing a significantly higher desire to visit South America than the US and Spanish participants. Those who were motivated to travel by the film were especially influenced by the scenery, landscape and the cultural attractions of the destination as depicted in the movie. Copyright © 2010 John Wiley & Sons, Ltd.

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Keywords: film tourism; destination image; South America; tourism marketing.

INTRODUCTION

The impact of films on people's image formation has been widely acknowledged in the literature (Butler, 1990; Riley and van Doren, 1992; Gartner, 1993; Schofield, 1996; Iwashita, 2003; Kim and Richardson, 2003). Films are not generally produced with the intent to attract tourists to a destination, but tend to influence viewers indirectly as a background part of the movie's message (Butler, 1990). This is because they can present millions of viewers with substantial information about a destination, create a first-time image or alter an existing image in a relatively short period of time (Hahm *et al.*, 2008). For a destination, the publicity generated by a major motion picture and by the high-profile actors can be tremendous (Beeton, 2005). Researchers have already asserted that films are more likely to reach wider audiences with less investment than specifically targeted tourism advertisements and promotion (Dore and Crouch, 2003). As a result, film-induced tourism or film tourism as it is referred to in this paper, can be an effective marketing tool for destinations that lack financial backing for strong advertising campaigns, especially at a time of economic downturn.

But despite the growing awareness of the relationship between film and tourism, as well as the anecdotal application of film tourism in destination marketing, the impacts of film tourism still appear to be under-appreciated. Though the effects of film tourism can be long lasting and have significant long-term economic and social effects, many tourism organizations have been slow to tap the potential

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benefits of film tourism, perhaps due to a lack of knowledge, research or evidence that explains the potential of film tourism (Hudson and Ritchie, 2006).

Academic research on film tourism has been around since the early 1990s, but the popularity and extensiveness of research in this area has increased in recent years (Hahm *et al.*, 2008), with most studies examining the increase of visitor numbers to film locations (Riley and van Doren, 1992; Cousins and Anderek, 1993; Schofield, 1996; Tooke and Baker, 1996; Riley *et al.*, 1998; Gundle, 2002; Busby *et al.*, 2003; Croy and Walker, 2003; Kim and Richardson, 2003; Beeton, 2005). But empirical studies attempting to measure the impact of films on the perception and behavioural aspects of the viewers relating to a specific destination are scarce, and understanding of the cultural implications pertinent to film-induced tourism is limited (Ryan *et al.*, 2009; O'Connor *et al.*, 2010).

To this end, several key issues warrant empirical investigation. First, does viewing a film in which a destination is depicted change the image of the viewer regarding the destination? Second, if viewing a film generates a certain level of motivation to visit a destination, what specific aspects of the film motivate viewers to visit the destination? Last but not least, does culture play any role in affecting how viewers respond to the films and their motivational appeals? In order to answer these questions, this study adopted an experimental design using established scales from the tourism and marketing literature to empirically measure the impacts of a film on the above dimensions by conducting before and after surveys.

THE IMPACT OF FILM ON TOURISM

Film tourism has been defined by Buchmann *et al.* (2010, p. 233) as 'visitation of a site or a location, that is or has been used for or is associated with filming'. The impact of film on tourism is well documented through a number of case studies and is recognized in the marketing campaigns of destination marketing organizations (DMOs) all over the world (Tooke and Baker, 1996; Riley *et al.*, 1998; Morgan *et al.*, 2003; Jones and Smith, 2005; O'Connor *et al.*,

2010). A survey in the UK found that 8 out of 10 Britons get their holiday destination ideas from films, and one in five will actually make the 'pilgrimage' (Beeton, 2005, p. 34) to the location of their favorite film ('Movies', 2004). Another recent study found that after family and friends and the Internet, television shows and films were the next key influencer on the decision to travel to a particular country. The survey found that 13% of people initially become interested in a country after seeing the destination on television or film (FutureBrand, 2008). Yet, we do not have a clear understanding of why and how, and very few researchers have explored the phenomenon in any detail (Iwashita, 2008; Mestre *et al.*, 2008). The idea that the whole audience for any film will respond by deciding to visit the location of the film is unlikely (Young and Young, 2008). But if some consumers are strongly influenced by the image portrayed through films, then there must be more focus on the consumer and the impact of such media on travel decisions (Bolan and Williams, 2008).

Urry (1990) suggested that places are chosen to be gazed upon because of anticipation generated through a variety of non-tourist activities such as film and television. In the same year, Butler predicted that as people placed less importance on reading as a form of getting information about places, and relied more on the visual form of information to gain knowledge, movies, videos and television would become even more important. He also suggested that the importance of the visual image in determining or shaping images and visitation is probably as great as it is unstudied.

Cohen (1986) proposed that movies can persuade the viewer with three different appeals — literary ethos, literary logos and literary pathos. In literary ethos, the vehicle of persuasion is an individual. It may be the screenwriter/director/producer, the actor or the fictional character that the actor portrays. Literary logos use logic and reasoning to persuade. Finally, literary pathos persuades by appealing to the emotions and is the most common type of media fiction. According to Cohen, these different appeals can overlap, as a movie can appeal to both logic and emotions. Riley and van Doren (1992) asserted that the

key for the construction of a favourable destination impression is a formula of idyllic or extraordinary landscape qualities, a unique social and cultural vantage point and/or an image that tourists identify with and wish to explore or rediscover. Building on this work, Riley *et al.* (1998) added the ingredients of storyline themes, exciting sequences and human relationships, suggesting that films create exotic worlds that do not exist in reality but can be recreated through a visit to the location(s) where they were filmed.

Similarly, Carl *et al.* (2007) suggested that when watching a film, the audience is plunged into a fantasy world in between the imaginary and the real and that film tourism is partly based on tourists' demands to escape into this in-between world and experience the cultural landscapes represented in films. Macionis (2004) suggested that film tourists will be motivated by one or more of three pull factors — *place* (location, attributes, landscapes, scenery), *personality* (cast, characters, celebrity) and *performance* (plot, theme, genre). It is this categorization that will be used in this study to investigate film tourism motivations, as it highlights the specific media representations and attributes that are important to film tourists.

THE IMPACT OF FILM ON DESTINATION IMAGE

It is widely accepted that a destination's image plays a major role in the destination selection process (Mayo and Jarvis, 1981; Fakeye and Crompton, 1991). The image consumers have of a destination is therefore of paramount importance in the marketing that is involved, but creating an image for a destination is not an easy task (Bolan and Williams, 2008). Images come from controlled and direct marketing initiatives by tourism organizations and indirectly from other sources including films and television programs. Just as product placements will influence a viewer's attitude towards a brand, so too will films have an impact on destination image if a location plays a prominent part in the film. Because destination images influence tourist behaviour, a destination must be favourably differentiated from its competition and positively positioned

in the minds of consumers (Echtner and Ritchie, 1993, 2003).

Schofield (1996) suggested that contemporary tourists' organic images of places are shaped through the vicarious consumption of film and television without the perceptual bias of promotional material. In support of this contention, Gundle (2002) discussed how the 1960 hit film *La Dolce Vita* transformed the image of Rome in Italy. In the minds of the public worldwide, Rome became the city of sin and pleasure; of Liz Taylor, Ava Gardner and Frank Sinatra; of elegance and night clubs; of aristocrats and Latin lovers; and of fast cars and stylish intellectuals. The image, perpetuated in American films and books, provided Roman tourist industries and fashion houses with a resource that has lasted to this present day. Roman glamour became Italian glamour for the world.

Further empirical proof of how films can impact destination image came from Kim and Richardson (2003) who employed an experimental design to assess the extent to which viewing a specific film altered cognitive and affective images of the place it depicted. They found that the 1995 movie *Before Sunrise* significantly affected some of the destination image components and interest in visiting Vienna in Austria. Warnick *et al.* (2005) also examined the effect of a movie on the image of Thailand among student travellers. However, as Croy and Walker (2003) have indicated, more research is needed to assess the evaluative components of image and to measure the effect films have on image. Likewise, Morgan and Pritchard (1998) claimed that the challenge for destination marketers is to find the best way to use images, stories and emotions to capture the tourist's attention and create the destination's brand.

Tourism organizations and film companies are beginning to work together to leverage film tourism (Cynthia and Beeton, 2009), and some DMOs have been particularly proactive. Tourism officials in Australia recently invested millions of dollars promoting their country on the tailcoats of the new blockbuster *Australia* that debuted in cinemas in November 2008. *Australia* is an epic movie starring two of Hollywood's biggest stars, Nicole Kidman and Hugh Jackman, and was directed by Baz

Luhrmann. The new branding campaign, conceived and produced by Luhrmann himself, ran for several months in Tourism Australia's international markets, to coincide with the worldwide marketing and release of the movie. With its dramatic locations and stunning cinematography, Australian tourism officials were hoping that the movie would make audiences all over the world fall in love with Australia and help to make the country a highly fashionable tourism destination. Although the movie was not a huge success, research carried out by Tourism Australia after the event suggested that the \$40 million spent on the 'Come Walkabout' branding campaign (still in use in some countries in 2010) was a sound investment and resonated particularly well in the US and UK markets (Tourism Australia, 2009).

FILM TOURISM, PRODUCT PLACEMENT AND CULTURAL IMPACT

Evidence can be found in the marketing literature for a strong link between film tourism and product placement (Morgan and Pritchard, 1998; Hall, 2004; Hudson and Hudson, 2006; Iwashita, 2008). Product placement via mass media is an emerging phenomenon and has been defined as the planned entries of products into movies or television shows that may influence viewers' product beliefs and/or behaviours favourably (Balasubramanian, 1994). According to Morgan and Pritchard (1998), a film that portrays a destination in a positive light is the ultimate in tourism media product placement. Film images persist for decades, providing publicity and creating identities. The exposure a film gives a city, province or country is an advertisement viewed by potentially millions of people, an audience that could not be reached through specifically targeted tourism promotions. Research studies have shown that films and television programs that are not concerned with tourism promotion can have a greater power to increase interest in travel to a destination than traditional tourism promotion materials (Iwashita, 2008).

Limited research has been conducted on media product placement, despite the growing usage of this promotional method (Hudson and Hudson, 2006). Several researchers have

indicated the importance of media product placement as an additional element of the promotional mix (Gould *et al.*, 2000), yet there is scope for further research concerning its theoretical underpinnings and practical implications (McKechnie and Zhou, 2003). Of the dozen or so studies related to product placement, none have looked at the 'placement' of destinations in movies and its influence on tourism. However, some of the findings do have relevance for those interested in film tourism. In most of the studies, respondents do have a positive view towards product placement, and it seems to increase brand loyalty by validating the purchase decisions of the consumer (Hart, 2003). Research confirms that product placement can have a greater impact with program audiences than is typically found with comparable advertising exposures (Karrh *et al.*, 2003). However, there are demographic and cross-cultural differences that could be important in market segmentation decisions. For example, young people respond better to product placement in movies, and European movie watchers object more than North Americans to product placement (Hall, 2004).

The measurement of product placement has also been the subject of much discussion. Among product placement practitioners, unaided recall and brand recognition have been used to assess placements, although the tracking of subsequent related sales or the measurement of trade or general press coverage are methods growing in use (Karrh *et al.*, 2003). The hierarchy of effects models can also be used to measure the impacts of placements. These models invariably assume that customers follow a number of predetermined stages, commencing with awareness and progressing to purchase. The most commonly cited model is that first proposed by Strong (1925), called the attention, interest, desire and action (AIDA) model. The reasoning behind this model is that communication should first attract the receiver's attention, then engage the receiver's interest, then create in the receiver a desire for the product or service, and then inspire action in the receiver.

Research has also indicated that the impact of a film is not likely to be homogeneous across viewers with different cultural backgrounds.

For example, Busby and Klug (2001) discussed the concept of film tourism in relation to the wider phenomenon of cultural tourism and its variations in interpretation. Their study found that a variety of different forms of film tourism exist, and every tourist is motivated by different factors to visit filmed locations based on cultural affiliations. Kim and Richardson (2003) provided empirical evidence that suggests that, probably due to individual characteristics, a popular movie could affect some of the destination image components and interest in visiting the filmed location. The authors also proposed that the level of empathic involvement with the film characters may have impact on cognitive or affective components of destination image. In addition, familiarity, including cultural familiarity, may lead to a different perception of the destination portrayed in the film.

METHODOLOGY

The objective of this study was to measure the immediate impacts of a film on the perceptions and behavioural aspects of the viewers relating to a specific destination as well as its cultural implications. An experimental design was adopted where a movie was used as a treatment to test its impacts by conducting before and after surveys. The film chosen for this experiment was the *Motorcycle Diaries*, described as 'a love story in the form of a travelogue' (Scott, 2004). In the film, Che Guevara and his colleague, Alberto Granado, travel through Latin America on motorcycles. Their trip covered around 5000 miles, west from Buenos Aires, Argentina, through Patagonia and into Chile, north along the Andes to Machu Picchu and finally to the Guajira Peninsula in Venezuela. The film was shot over a 16-week schedule, in sequence, and mainly at the real locations of the Latin American journey. This film was chosen because it can be viewed in both Spanish and English (and so allows a cross-cultural perspective) and, according to tourism officials, was 'a fantastic showcase for South America' (R. Skipsey, personal communication, 2006). A number of tour operators capitalized on the film. British-based 'Journey Latin America', for example, offered a three-week escorted 'Motorcycle Diaries tour' from

Buenos Aires to Lima. The company also had tailor-made trips to any of the locations along the Guevara–Granado route.

In order to gain a cross-cultural perspective, the experiment was conducted in three different countries. This allowed the researchers to investigate the relationship between cultural background and motivations to visit destinations seen in the film. The sample consisted of students from Canada ($n = 74$), USA ($n = 141$) and Spain ($n = 67$). Of the sample of 282, 91 (32%) were male and 191 (68%) were female.

A survey was administered to the respondents before and after watching the film. First, the participants were asked to indicate on a Likert scale ranging from 1 (strongly disagree) to 7 (strongly agree) the extent to which they agreed with 34 cognitive attributes as being representative of South America as a destination. The attributes were based on the destination image scale developed by Echtner and Ritchie (1993), with adjustment and revisions made to reflect destination attributes in South America depicted in the movie (see Table 1 for attributes used in the survey). The second part of the survey applied methods used in previous research to measure the impact of product placements of the movie through the hierarchy of effects model — the AIDA model. The AIDA communication model originally proposed by Strong (1925) was used to understand to what extent the respondents were aware of South America as a suitable tourism destination for them, their desire to visit South America, the likelihood that they would book a vacation to South America in the future and their level of interest in getting more information on travelling to South America. Respondents who stated that the movie inspired them to visit South America were then asked to state which factors influenced them the most using the three different motivational appeals — place, performance and personality — as proposed by Macionis (2004), to see which had the most persuasion power on viewers.

RESULTS

Consistent with the original measure, the image scale was grouped into eight factors (see Table 1). These eight factors are termed as comfort/security, interest/adventure, natural

Table 1. Results of paired sample *t*-test and reliability test for destination image change

Scale item	Mean before*	Mean after	Mean difference	Significance (<i>df</i> = 190)	Alpha (before/after)
Factor 1: comfort/security					0.74/0.75
Local standards of cleanliness and hygiene are high.	4.67	5.10	0.43	0.000 (<i>t</i> = 4.287)	
There is a high standard of living.	4.93	5.36	0.43	0.000 (<i>t</i> = 4.166)	
Good quality restaurants and hotels are easy to find.	4.24	5.02	0.78	0.000 (<i>t</i> = 7.027)	
Highways and roads are in good condition.	4.77	5.34	0.57	0.000 (<i>t</i> = 4.914)	
In general, it is a safe place to visit.	4.66	4.41	-0.25	0.022 (<i>t</i> = 2.303)	
Shopping facilities are well maintained.	3.79	4.29	0.50	0.000 (<i>t</i> = 4.710)	
It is easy to get good service in restaurants and hotels.	3.38	3.50	0.12	0.313 (<i>t</i> = 1.011)	
Cities are attractive.	3.69	3.66	-0.03	0.826 (<i>t</i> = 0.220)	
There is political stability.	4.88	4.87	0.01	0.958 (<i>t</i> = 0.052)	
Local people are friendly.	3.11	2.53	-0.57	0.000 (<i>t</i> = 6.391)	
Composite mean	4.21	4.41	0.19	0.000 (<i>t</i> = 4.287)	
Factor 2: interest/adventure					0.80/0.76
A holiday in South America is a real adventure.	3.02	2.71	-0.31	0.010 (<i>t</i> = 2.616)	
Everything is different and fascinating.	3.22	2.66	-0.56	0.000 (<i>t</i> = 5.511)	
There are many places of interest to visit.	2.59	2.26	-0.33	0.001 (<i>t</i> = 3.304)	
Good destination for an educational or learning experience.	3.14	2.62	-0.52	0.000 (<i>t</i> = 4.401)	
Many places of historical or archaeological interest.	2.60	2.31	-0.29	0.013 (<i>t</i> = 2.521)	
Many opportunities to see interesting local festivals.	2.81	2.95	0.13	0.169 (<i>t</i> = 1.380)	
Composite mean	2.90	2.56	-0.34	0.000 (<i>t</i> = 5.703)	
Factor 3: natural state					0.62/0.67
Plenty of places to get away from the crowds.	3.35	2.86	-0.49	0.000 (<i>t</i> = 4.628)	
Restful and relaxing place to visit.	3.44	3.56	0.11	0.313 (<i>t</i> = 1.011)	
Offers a lot in terms of natural scenic beauty.	2.34	1.82	-0.52	0.000 (<i>t</i> = 5.439)	
Abundant number of nature preserves and wilderness areas.	2.56	2.15	-0.41	0.000 (<i>t</i> = 3.737)	
Composite mean	2.92	2.60	-0.32	0.000 (<i>t</i> = 5.523)	
Factor 4: touristic facilitation					0.71/0.76
Many packaged vacations available.	3.97	4.45	0.48	0.000 (<i>t</i> = 4.431)	
Good tourist information is readily available.	3.77	4.44	0.67	0.000 (<i>t</i> = 5.493)	
Tours and excursions are readily available.	3.50	4.11	0.61	0.000 (<i>t</i> = 5.672)	
Tourist attractions are well known and famous.	4.20	4.21	0.01	0.932 (<i>t</i> = 0.086)	
Composite mean	3.86	4.30	0.44	0.000 (<i>t</i> = 5.983)	

Table 1. *Continued*

Scale item	Mean before*	Mean after	Mean difference	Significance (df = 190)	Alpha (before/after)
Factor 5: resort atmosphere/climate					0.68/0.55
Good place to go for the beaches	2.96	3.92	0.96	0.000 ($t = 7.387$)	
Has good nightlife	3.56	3.93	0.37	0.000 ($t = 3.552$)	
Has pleasant weather	2.78	2.96	0.18	0.084 ($t = 1.737$)	
Composite mean	3.10	3.60	0.50	0.000 ($t = 5.671$)	
Factor 6: cultural similarity					0.79/0.81
Lifestyle and customs are similar to ours.	5.02	5.21	0.19	0.042 ($t = 2.050$)	
Food is similar to ours.	5.12	5.19	0.07	0.394 ($t = 0.854$)	
Local architectural styles are similar to ours.	5.00	5.28	0.28	0.005 ($t = 2.826$)	
Composite mean	5.05	5.23	0.18	0.005 ($t = 2.837$)	
Factor 7: inexpensiveness					0.59/0.73
Prices are low.	3.49	3.28	-0.21	0.042 ($t = 2.050$)	
Goods and services are affordable.	3.27	3.07	-0.20	0.041 ($t = 2.059$)	
Composite mean	3.38	3.12	-0.26	0.003 ($t = 3.037$)	
Factor 8: lack of language barrier					0.77/0.85
Many people understand English/Spanish.	3.78	4.74	0.96	0.000 ($t = 8.518$)	
Many people speak English/Spanish.	4.13	5.01	0.88	0.000 ($t = 7.835$)	
Composite mean	3.96	4.88	0.92	0.000 ($t = 9.824$)	

*Mean value measured on a Likert scale of 1–7 where 1 = strongly agree and 7 = strongly disagree.
df, degrees of freedom.

state, touristic facilitation, resort atmosphere/climate, cultural similarity, inexpensiveness and lack of language barrier. Since the scale and its structure have been validated in previous studies, only confirmatory factor analyses were applied to the participants for both pre-movie and post-movie in order to test the reliability of each factor to confirm its structure. The structure was generally supported by Cronbach alpha scores for both pre- and post-movie. For pre-movie, five factors (comfort/security, interest/adventure, touristic facilitation, cultural similarity and lack of language barrier) obtained reliability scores of more than 0.70, recommended by Nunnally (1967) and Robinson *et al.* (1991). The other three factors' (inexpensiveness, natural state and resort atmosphere/climate) reliability scores ranged between 0.59 and 0.68, demonstrating reasonably good reliability of the factor structures. For post-movie, the structure of most of the factors improved, with six factors (comfort/

security, interest/adventure, touristic facilitation, cultural similarity, inexpensiveness and lack of language barrier) obtaining a reliability score of more than 0.70. While the factor 'resort atmosphere/climate' showed a relatively low reliability score of 0.55, the factor 'natural state' obtained a reliability score of 0.67, which is close to the recommended score of 0.70.

The change in composite mean scores for each factor shows that the film had a highly significant impact for all factors ($p < 0.001$) (see Table 1). For three of the factors (interest/adventure, natural state and inexpensiveness), the mean change was a positive one, whereas for the other five factors (comfort/security, touristic facilitation, resort atmosphere/climate, cultural similarity and lack of language barrier), the mean change in image perception was a negative one. When examining the impact of the movie on destination image change at the individual item level under each of the factors, significant differences were

found for most items at the 0.05 significance level. The direction of the item change generally reflected the direction of the composite mean change at the factor level. For example, the change directions for most of the items under comfort/security, touristic facilitation, resort atmosphere/climate, cultural similarity and lack of language barrier were negative, whereas the change directions for most of the items under interest/adventure, natural state and inexpensiveness were positive. The movie showed no significant impact on image change at the 0.05 significance level in only 8 of the 34 image attributes used in the study: 'it is easy to get good service in restaurants and hotels', 'cities are attractive' and 'there is political stability' under comfort/security; 'many opportunities to see interesting local festivals' under interest/adventure; 'restful and relaxing place to visit' under natural state; 'tourist attractions are well known and famous' under touristic facilitation; 'has pleasant weather' under resort atmosphere/climate; and 'food is similar to ours' under cultural similarity.

To measure the impact of the film on the hierarchy of effects dimensions, pre- and post-means of the AIDA model were compared for each of the three nationalities (see Table 2). For the Canadian students, the movie had a statistically positive significant impact on awareness ($t = 3.61, p < 0.001$), desire to visit ($t = 3.83, p < 0.001$) and intention to book ($t = 3.85, p < 0.001$). The same pattern was revealed for the Florida students: the movie had a statistically positive significant impact on awareness ($t = 5.57, p < 0.001$), desire to visit ($t = 2.81, p < 0.001$) and intention to book ($t = 4.15, p < 0.001$). However, the movie had no statistically significant impact on the Spanish students in all the four aspects of the hierarchy of effects model.

Mean differences were also tested for both pre- and post-movie to identify differences among the three groups based on the hierarchy of effects model. For awareness, significant differences were found among the three groups ($F = 7.38, p < 0.001$) for post-movie means ($m = 4.74, 4.28$ and 3.75 for the participants from Canada, Florida and Spain respectively). Post hoc tests using the Tukey procedure indicated that the means for the Canadian and Florida participants were significantly higher than that for the Spanish participants. No statistically

significant differences were revealed among the three groups before the movie in awareness.

For interest in getting more information, significant differences were identified among the three groups for both pre-movie ($F = 4.90, p < 0.01$) and post-movie ($F = 7.39, p < 0.001$). Post hoc tests indicated that the mean for the Canadian participants was significantly higher than the Florida and Spanish participants before the movie, and the same pattern was also observed after the movie. With desire to visit, significant differences were revealed among the three groups after the movie ($F = 9.56, p < 0.001$), with the Canadians showing a significantly higher desire to visit than both the Florida and Spanish participants. No significant differences were identified among the three groups before the movie for desire to visit.

Regarding intention to book, significant differences were found among the three groups for both before the movie ($F = 3.35, p < 0.001$) and after the movie ($F = 7.50, p < 0.001$). Post hoc tests demonstrated that Canadian participants had a significantly stronger intention to book than their Spanish counterparts before the movie, while after seeing the movie, the Canadian participants demonstrated a stronger intention to book than both their Florida and Spanish counterparts.

In terms of motivational appeals, the respondents who stated that the movie inspired them to visit South America were asked to state which factors influenced them the most based on the pull factors (i.e. place, performance and personality) proposed by Macionis (2004). Based on the unique nature of the movie, three items were developed for the factor place (i.e. scenery, landscape and the cultural attraction of the destination), three items for the factor performance (i.e. the storyline or plot of the film, the experiences of people in the film and the romance and adventure in the film) and another two items for the factor personality (i.e. the actors in the film, the characteristics portrayed by the actors). The influences of all the items under each of the factors are measured using a 7-point scale where 1 is very little influence and 7 is a great deal of influence, and the results are presented in Table 3. Detected from the overall means, the results seem to suggest that place demonstrates the biggest

Table 2. Cultural comparisons of impact of the film according to hierarchy of effects model (AIDA)

Effects of film (AIDA)		Canada	Florida	Spain	Overall <i>F</i>	Overall sig.	Tukey HSD sig.
Awareness	Pre-movie mean*	4.12 (1.77)	3.57 (1.70)	3.88 (1.44)	2.76	0.065	0.058 (C-F)
	Post-movie mean	4.74 (1.57)	4.28 (1.50)	3.75 (1.49)	7.38	0.001	0.663 (C-S)
		$t = 3.61,$ Sig. = 0.001	$t = -5.57,$ Sig. = 0.000	$t = 0.73,$ Sig. = 0.468			0.429 (F-S)
							0.096 (C-F)
Interest in visiting/ getting more info	Pre-movie mean	4.80 (1.60)	4.13 (1.83)	3.94 (1.79)	4.90	0.008	0.025 (C-F)
	Post-movie mean	4.99 (1.60)	4.24 (1.78)	3.97 (1.48)	7.39	0.001	0.012 (C-S)
		$t = 1.33,$ Sig. = 0.188	$t = 1.05,$ Sig. = 0.297	$t = 0.15,$ Sig. = 0.879			0.738 (F-S)
							0.006 (C-F)
Desire to visit	Pre-movie mean	4.55 (1.59)	3.96 (1.84)	4.07 (1.65)	2.95	0.054	0.045 (C-F)
	Post-movie mean	5.07 (1.49)	4.26 (1.63)	3.96 (1.62)	9.56	0.000	0.230 (C-S)
		$t = 3.83,$ Sig. = 0.000	$t = 2.81,$ Sig. = 0.006	$t = 0.61,$ Sig. = 0.546			0.892 (F-S)
							0.002 (C-F)
Intention to book	Pre-movie mean	3.68 (1.86)	3.13 (1.84)	2.94 (1.65)	3.35	0.037	0.088 (C-F)
	Post-movie mean	4.18 (1.61)	3.59 (1.74)	3.07 (1.67)	7.50	0.001	0.043 (C-S)
		$t = 3.85,$ Sig. = 0.000	$t = 4.15,$ Sig. = 0.000	$t = 0.80,$ Sig. = 0.429			0.764 (F-S)
							0.042 (C-F)
							0.000 (C-S)
							0.106 (F-S)

*Mean value measured on a Likert scale of 1–7 where 1 indicates the low end and 7 indicates the high end.
AIDA, attention, interest, desire and action; sig., significance; HSD, Honestly Significant Difference.

influence, while personality reveals the smallest influence among the three factors. More specifically, as indicated in Table 3, landscape ($m = 6.25$) and scenery ($m = 6.15$) were the two most important items inspiring the participants to visit South America, followed by the cultural attraction of the destination ($m = 5.32$), the experiences of the people in the film ($m = 4.79$) and the storyline or plot of the film ($m = 4.31$). The influence of the romance and adventure in the film ($m = 4.01$), the characters portrayed by the actors ($m = 3.97$) and the actors in the film ($m = 3.15$) were not so significant.

Analysis of variance tests were also applied to examine whether differences existed among the three groups on the three pull factors, and the results were also reported in Table 3. No statistically significant differences were identified on the three items (scenery, landscape, the cultural attraction of the destination) of the first factor *place*. However, significant group differences were found for the three items under *performance*: the storyline or plot of the film ($F = 3.31, p < 0.05$), the experiences of people in the film ($F = 15.86, p < 0.001$) and the romance and adventure in the film ($F = 9.42,$

Table 3. Cultural comparisons of the impact of the film on motivational appeals

		Overall mean*	Canada	Florida	Spain	Overall <i>F</i>	Overall sig.	Tukey HSD sig.
Place	Scenery	6.15	5.88 (1.38)	6.36 (0.78)	6.11 (1.39)	2.51	0.085	0.070 (C-F)
	Landscape	6.25	6.06 (1.21)	6.29 (0.78)	6.43 (0.20)	1.45	0.237	0.628 (C-S)
	The cultural attraction of the destination	5.32	5.52 (1.56)	5.42 (1.29)	4.89 (1.79)	2.04	0.133	0.531 (F-S)
								0.475 (C-F)
								0.224 (C-S)
								0.769 (F-S)
								0.939 (C-F)
								0.146 (C-S)
								0.203 (F-S)
								0.803 (C-F)
Performance	The storyline or plot of the film	4.31	4.38 (1.66)	4.57 (1.35)	3.76 (1.71)	3.31	0.039	0.160 (C-S)
	The experiences of people in the film	4.79	5.15 (1.28)	5.18 (1.24)	3.65 (1.84)	15.86	0.000	0.032 (F-S)
	The romance and adventure in the film	4.01	4.35 (1.66)	4.30 (1.48)	3.03 (1.66)	9.42	0.000	0.994 (C-F)
								0.000 (C-S)
								0.000 (F-S)
								0.984 (C-F)
								0.001 (C-S)
								0.000 (F-S)
								0.550 (C-F)
								0.636 (C-S)
Personality	The actors in the film	3.15	3.08 (1.61)	3.41 (1.67)	2.76 (1.64)	1.92	0.151	0.134 (F-S)
	The characters portrayed by the actors	3.97	4.40 (1.66)	4.05 (1.65)	3.30 (1.96)	4.29	0.015	0.541 (C-F)
								0.012 (C-S)
								0.094 (F-S)

*Mean value measured on a Likert scale of 1–7 where 1 = very little influence and 7 = a great deal of influence.
 sig., significance; HSD, Honestly Significant Difference.

$p < 0.001$). For *personality*, significant differences were identified among the three groups on the characters portrayed by the actors ($F = 4.29$, $p < 0.05$). In general, Spanish students were significantly less likely than the other groups to be influenced by the *performance* and *personality* motivational appeals of the film.

DISCUSSION

It was interesting to note that for only three of the destination image scale factors (interest/adventure, natural state and inexpensiveness), the impact of the film was positive, whereas for the other five (comfort/security, touristic facilitation, resort atmosphere/climate, cultural similarity and lack of language barrier), the change in image perception was negative. The positive changes are self-explanatory given that the means were only analysed for those inspired to visit South America. Potential visitors would be expected to be motivated by lower prices than anticipated and the fact that the destination would offer them interest and adventure. The respondents were also impressed by the nature and wilderness aspects of South America as depicted in the film. This explains why *place* was the number one motivator and supports the work of Riley and van Doren (1992) and Buchmann *et al.* (2010) who stressed the importance of landscape qualities and a unique social and cultural vantage point in motivating film tourists.

The negative changes in image are not as easily explained, but it seems that the image of South America before seeing the film was for a higher level of comfort and security, and touristic facilitation. The respondents were also expecting more in terms of resort atmosphere and climate, cultural similarity and a lack of language barrier. However, these factors do not seem to have affected their desire to visit the countries featured in the film, suggesting that they are not key influencers for this demographic. This could be explained by the theory of cultural distance, which refers to the differences between the culture from where the tourist originates and the culture of the host region. McIntosh and Goeldner (1990) suggested that the greater the cultural distance between the tourist's origin and a destination, the more a tourist may want to travel to that

particular destination in order to experience such extreme difference. The cultural and language differences were not a deterrent for the respondents. These findings also lend partial support to the theory that even an unfavourable portrayal in a film may result in viewers wishing to visit a destination (Croy and Walker, 2003). However, the volume of work in the field of destination image emphasizes the need for destinations to develop favourable images (Pike, 2002; Garrod, 2009), and marketers in South America should be concerned with some of the high mean scores in Table 1.

The results also support previous research that has found cross-cultural differences in responses to product or destination placement (McKechnie and Zhou, 2003; Hall, 2004). The movie had no significant impact on the Spanish students in all the four aspects of the hierarchy of effects model, and the Spanish students were significantly less likely than the North American students to be influenced by the performance and personality motivational appeals of the film. This again could be because of cultural distance, and would explain why North American students, and not Spanish students, were more attracted to the idea of visiting South America. The cultural differences were an attractor for the North American respondents.

The study also has important practical implications. Even though the film did not take place in Bolivia, the country developed a 'Che Guevara trail' following the release of the film, and bookings to the region surged 30% (Bentham, 2006). This confirms that if leveraged well, film tourism can have large economic gains for destinations. In the UK for example, around 1 in 10 foreign visitors come as a result of seeing the country depicted in film, and their spending in 2006 amounted to 1.8 billion pounds sterling. As a result of this spending, around 20000 jobs were supported in the UK, contributing an additional 900 million pounds to gross domestic product (Oxford Economics, 2007).

The results would suggest that South America is an attractive destination for many North Americans, so DMOs (apart from those in Bolivia) could have done more to leverage the film by targeting potential tourists more effectively. The potential of film tourism is all

too often not fully recognized by DMOs who do not exploit the 'destination image enhancement' opportunities that exist through the medium of film (Bolan and Williams, 2008; Liou, 2010). There are exceptions. The Bahamas' Ministry of Tourism is very proactive in leveraging film tourism opportunities (Hudson, 2008), and New Zealand has capitalized on the success of *The Lord of the Rings* in its marketing campaigns (Buchmann *et al.*, 2010). More recently (as mentioned previously), Tourism Australia invested millions of dollars promoting their country on the tailcoats of the movie *Australia*.

The Tourism Australia campaign was targeting certain markets (including the USA), and when leveraging the placement of a destination in film, it is important to consider segmentation and targeting. For example, a few years ago, marketers from Yukon Tourism in Canada partnered with French and Italian distributors of the film *Le Dernier Trappeur*. Although the film was made in English, it was dubbed into French, Italian and German, and distributed in those countries, because they were strong tourism markets for Yukon's tourism industry. The film was seen as a viable investment in strengthening awareness of the destination with the scenic qualities of the film and the exotic nature of the lifestyle portrayed in the storyline. Yukon's tourism marketing branch negotiated credits to appear right at the beginning of the film, making it clear to viewers that the film was shot in Yukon. Such targeting strategies underlie the need for research that analyses cross-cultural responses to destination images presented in films.

Despite the examples above, and the fact that many destinations have acknowledged the potential of film-induced tourism and how it can create a powerful destination image, few destinations have retained control over how and to whom the destination is presented through films and television series (O'Connor *et al.*, 2008). In the future, destinations will have to be more proactive in leveraging the advantages of film tourism.

LIMITATIONS AND FUTURE RESEARCH

There are limitations to the study that need to be acknowledged. First, it is recognized that by

restricting this study to a student population, there are limitations to generalizing results to the wider population. Tourism is a product sold to people of all ages, and results could differ if researchers conducted the survey with different demographic groups (Litvin, 2008). However, this factor also has advantages, since the vast majority of the students have not yet visited South America. Thus, it decreased the possibility that the participants would be influenced by past experience and allows for a more accurate examination of the film's influence on their perceptions. Yet, there is a need for future research among more representative samples. A second limitation is the focus on just one movie and one location. Future research could explore the impacts of different movie genres and other movie locations. In particular, researchers have highlighted the need for more studies on the influence of films with controversial or negative plots (Beeton, 2006). Third, the research adopted an experimental study design, which is naturally characterized with different conditions than the usual movie-going situation. Future studies could involve surveying viewers in an actual movie theatre, as this might yield different results. Lastly, it is important to note that the study examined behavioural intentions, as opposed to actual behaviour. There is no guarantee that increase in the mean score of the behavioural intentions will be translated to visitation to South America.

Despite the limitations, this is a unique and important piece of research and is one of the first attempts to measure the immediate impacts of a film on the perceptions of viewers from different countries. The study has shown that a film can have a very powerful impact on destination image and the decision to travel, and therefore makes an important contribution to the field of tourism marketing and film tourism in particular.

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